

The Ancient Faith: Early Church Fathers and the Path of the Tewahedo Church

By Dn Yonnas · Church History · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

A journey through the early Church: the Apostolic Sees, the 1,600-year bond between Alexandria and Ethiopia, the three Ecumenical Councils we accept (Nicaea, Constantinople, Ephesus), the conflict at Chalcedon (451 AD), the meaning of Miaphysitism and the Ge'ez word Tewahedo, and the Nine Saints who planted monasticism in Ethiopia.

Lesson Objectives

- Trace the apostolic roots of the Church and the place of Alexandria among the ancient Sees
- Explain which councils the Tewahedo Church accepts and why Chalcedon was rejected
- Tell the story of the Nine Saints and their monasteries

Key Bible Verses

Matthew 16:18 — "on this rock I will build My church"

Acts 8:26–39 — the baptism of the Ethiopian eunuch

Jude 1:3 — "contend earnestly for the faith which was once for all delivered to the saints"

Main Teaching Points

- Authority in the early Church gathered around the Apostolic Sees, Alexandria among the first
- The Ethiopian Church received her bishops from Alexandria for some 1,600 years
- We uphold Nicaea I, Constantinople I, and Ephesus I
- The Alexandrian delegation rejected Chalcedon's 'in two natures' as endangering the unity of Christ
- Miaphysis: one united nature of God the Word incarnate — Tewahedo means 'made one'
- The Nine Saints, fleeing after Chalcedon, evangelized Ethiopia and founded her great monasteries

Key Terms

- **Apostolic See** — A city-church founded by an Apostle or his direct disciple, e.g., Alexandria, Antioch, Rome.
- **Miaphysitism** — The Oriental Orthodox confession of one united incarnate nature of God the Word — not 'monophysitism.'
- **Ge'ez** — The ancient liturgical language of the Ethiopian Church; 'Tewahedo' is a Ge'ez word meaning 'made one.'
- **The Nine Saints** — Monastic missionaries who came to Ethiopia after Chalcedon and founded her great monasteries.
- **Chalcedon** — The 451 AD council whose 'in two natures' formula the Oriental Orthodox churches rejected.

Discussion & Reflection

- Why does apostolic succession matter for trusting what the Church teaches?
- What was the real concern behind rejecting the language of Chalcedon?

- What can the Nine Saints teach us about turning exile into mission?

Debre Nazreth St. Mary & St. Gabriel Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church — STL Theology Class
Glory be to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, one God. Amen.